Pudding

A dog companion that helps you stay focused

“Gentle companionship + nudges to reduce anxiety and help users start and sustain focus.”

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Problems

The Feedback Vacuum: Self-directed remote workers and students lose momentum during deep work because progress feels invisible and external validation is missing.

The Anxiety Loop: Traditional productivity tools rely on rigid tracking and guilt, which increases anxiety and triggers avoidance rather than helping.

High Startup Friction: Users struggle to initiate focus because the rigid setup of traditional timers feels like a demanding chore.

Current tools focus on strict productivity rather than emotional support.

Solution: A Low-Pressure Desktop Companion

Value Proposition:

Pudding! empowers self-directed workers to overcome the "Anxiety Loop" by providing a non-judgmental, low-pressure presence that validates effort even when progress is invisible.

Ambient Desktop Presence:

A desktop-exclusive companion that provides a "social gaze" to maintain focus, utilizing Smart Dodging / Transparency so it never obstructs professional workspaces like Figma or VS Code.

Gentle Re-Entry Rituals:

Replaces rigid timers with neutral, judgment-free states (e.g., Pudding takes a "Nap" during breaks) to help users recover from distractions without triggering the Anxiety Loop or guilt.

Invisible Progress Validation:

Translates isolating, self-directed work sessions into ambient emotional support, closing the Feedback Vacuum without demanding high-friction inputs or performance tracking.

Presentation Outline

1. **Problem & Solution**
   Why Pudding exists and what it does
2. **Heuristic Evaluation Results**
   26 violations identified, severity breakdown, key trends
3. **Major Violations Addressed**
   All severity 3-4 fixes with rationale
4. **Lower-Severity Violations**
   Deferred items and justifications
5. **TA Feedback Addressed**
   5 specific TA comments and how each was fixed
6. **Before & After Comparisons**
   Visual side-by-side of key screen revisions
7. **Progress Toward Usability Goals**
   Impact on startup friction and support-without-pressure goals
8. **What Makes Pudding Different**
   Competitive differentiation from existing tools
9. **Prototype**
   Interactive Figma prototype link

Heuristic Evaluation Summary

Total violations identified: **26**

Severity 1

1 = cosmetic

minor issues

Severity 2

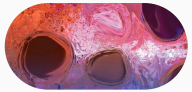
2 = minor

several issues

Severity 3

3 = major

4 issues



Severity 4

4 = UI catastrophe

2 issues

Most violated: **H3 User Control & Freedom (5)** · **H1 Visibility of System Status (4)** · **H5 Error Prevention (3)**

Total UI revisions: **12 changes** to address all severity 3-4 violations, plus **5 severity 1-2 items** intentionally deferred.

Key insight: The concentration of violations in user control and system visibility drove our revision strategy — prioritizing clearer navigation, confirmation dialogs, plain-language status labels, and visible progress feedback.

Major Issue #1

Return to Work leads to wrong session

Severity: **4**

1

Problem

When users click **Pause** → **Return to Work**, the system incorrectly redirects to a different focus session.

2

Fix

Return to Work now correctly returns the user to **the original session they paused**.

3

Impact

Improves **consistency and workflow continuity**.

Major Issue #2

Tasks cannot start another focus session

Severity: **4**

1

Problem

After finishing a focus session for a task, the user could not start another session for the same task.

2

Fix

Tasks can now start **multiple focus sessions repeatedly**.

3

Impact

Restores expected task workflow and improves usability..

Major Issue #3

Users could not delete tasks

Severity: **3**

1

Problem

Tasks added to the task list could not be removed.

Over time the list could become cluttered.

2

Fix

We added a **Delete Task option** on the task page.

Users can now remove tasks they no longer need.

3

Impact

Improves **user control and freedom**.

Major Issue #4

Focus session time was fixed

Severity: **3**

1

Problem

All focus sessions were locked to **25 minutes**.

However, different users prefer different work intervals.

2

Fix

We added an option to **adjust focus session duration** before starting.

3

Impact

Improves **flexibility and alignment with real-world workflows**.

Additional Improvements

We also addressed several medium-severity issues:

1

Added **confirmation dialog** before ending a session

2

Added **Total Time metric** to the summary screen

3

Fixed **Back button navigation**

4

Improved **UI consistency across screens**

UI and Design Improvements

We also made several design improvements:

1

Reduced repetitive text on the reflection screen

2

Adjusted button colors to match common conventions

3

Improved layout consistency between screens

4

Adjusted UI elements to avoid overlapping components

Impact of These Changes

1

Users now have better control over tasks and sessions..

2

The workflow is more consistent and predictable.

3

The interface is cleaner and easier to navigate.

4

These improvements move Pudding closer to a **usable high-fidelity prototype suitable for usability testing**.

Lower-Severity Violations: Deferred

All severity 3-4 violations were addressed. These severity 1-2 items were intentionally deferred.

- **Time format consistency (Sev 1)**
  Already consistent — "min" abbreviation used throughout all screens. No user-facing issue; cosmetic only.
- **Auto-Move bar visible during focus sessions (Sev 2)**
  Intentional design choice: users may need to adjust Pudding's opacity or position mid-session without breaking flow.
- **Heading hierarchy in panel (Sev 2)**
  Structural HTML concern that does not affect visual design, usability, or the user's ability to complete tasks.
- **Keyboard shortcuts / undo support (Sev 1-2)**
  Deferred to the engineering phase. Keyboard navigation and undo are out of scope for a Figma prototype.
- **Tooltip text truncation at small sizes (Sev 1)**
  Edge case at extreme window sizes. The desktop companion runs at a fixed position and is not resizable by the user.

Summary: 4/4 severity-4 and 8/8 severity-3 violations addressed. Remaining items are cosmetic or deferred to development.

Addressing TA Feedback from GR6

5 specific issues raised by the TA — all addressed in this revision

❶ "Steps shown but user didn't define any"

TA saw "2/4 steps done" after a quick-start session with no task.

Fix: Quick-start sessions now hide step metrics. Task-linked sessions list step names with checkmarks.

❷ "Can't add a task — not in task flow"

TA could not add any task; the feature was visual-only.

Fix: Full Add Task composer with title, duration chips (15/25/45 min), step list with add/delete, Save/Cancel.

❸ "What is nudge? RUNNING / NUDGED unclear"

TA didn't understand internal state labels.

Fix: All labels replaced with plain language — "Hey, still there?", "Pudding is napping...", "Session Complete".

❹ "First screen should show tasks, not quick-start"

Home screen led with Deep Focus presets, not task management.

Fix: Home is now tasks-first. First-time users see "Add Your First Task". Quick Start demoted to secondary row.

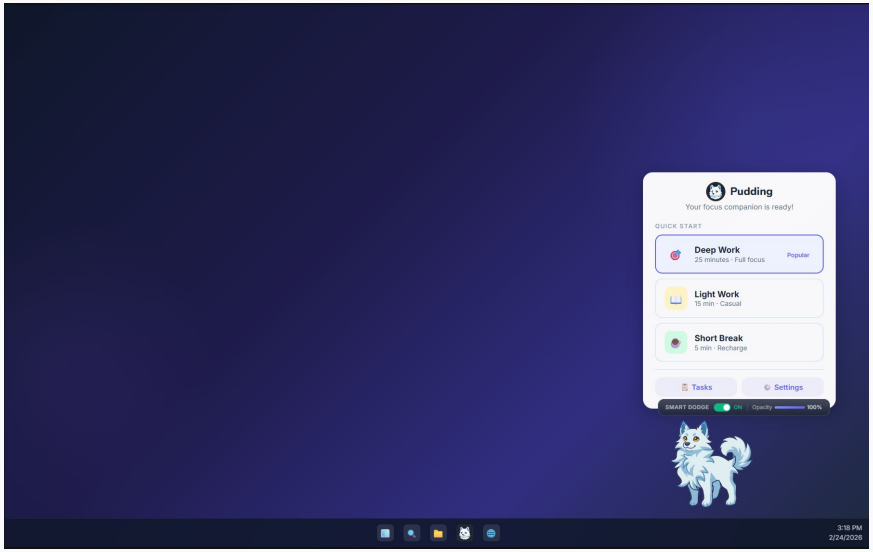
❺ "No visuals that motivate users to keep going"

TA noted all changes focused on avoiding negatives, with nothing to encourage users.

Fix: Celebrating Pudding with sparkles on completion, "Pudding is proud of you!", progress bars, step checkmarks, and expression changes per state (focused → sleepy → proud).

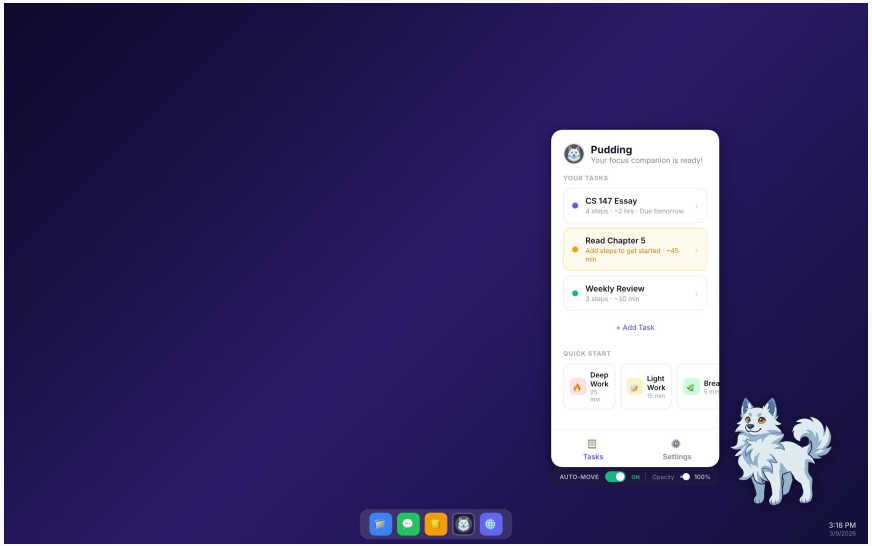
Before & After: Tasks-First Home

BEFORE (GR6)



Quick-start presets dominated the home screen.
No task management visible.

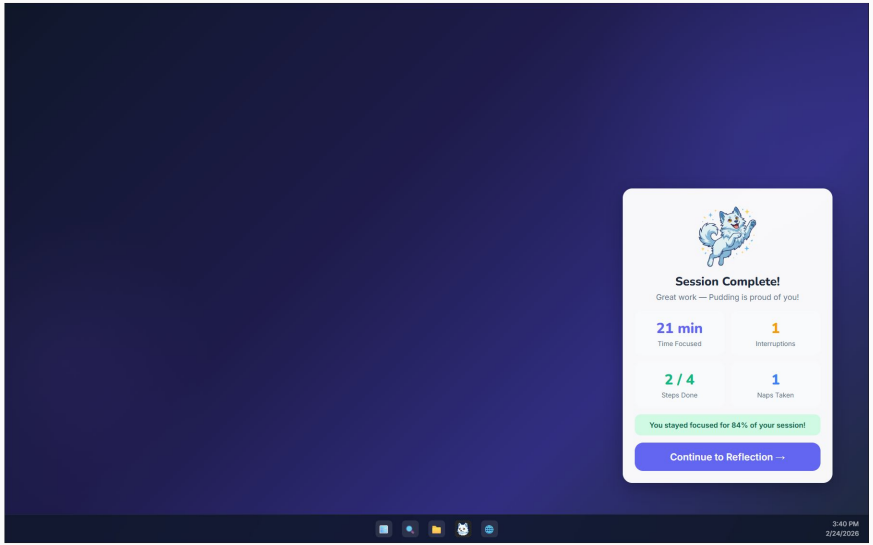
AFTER (GR8)



Task list is now primary. Quick Start is demoted.
'+ Add Task' is prominent.

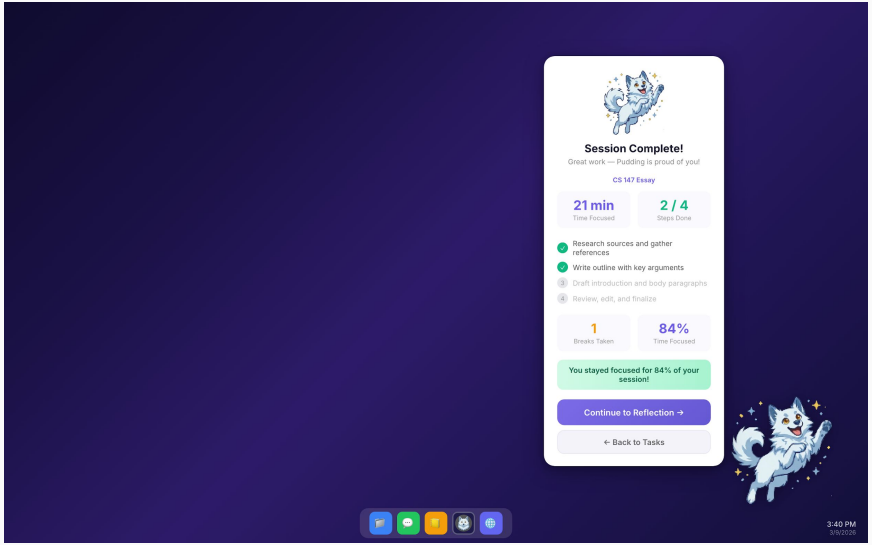
Before & After: Context-Aware Session Summary

BEFORE (GR6)



"2/4 Steps Done" and "Interruptions" shown even for sessions without tasks. Metrics unexplained.

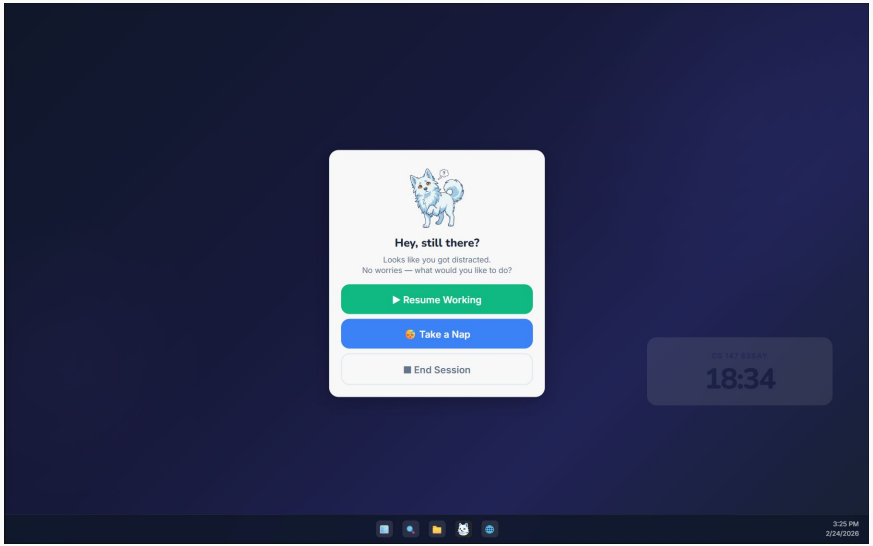
AFTER (GR8)



Task-linked summary lists completed step names. Quick-start hides step metrics. 'Interruptions' removed.

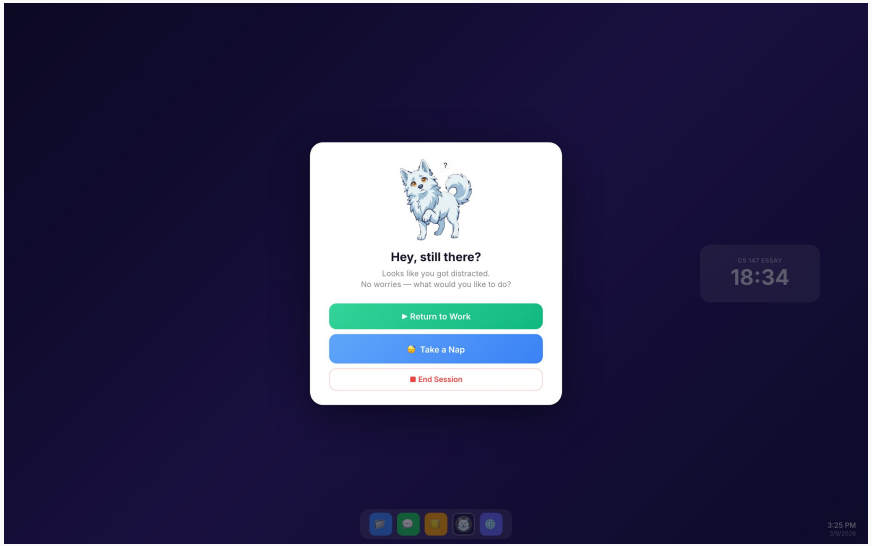
Before & After: Plain-Language States + End Confirmation

BEFORE (GR6)



"Resume Working" label. No confirmation before ending.
End and Pause buttons were same size.

AFTER (GR8)



"Return to Work" standardized. End requires confirmation.
Pause is large, End is small/red text.

Progress Toward Usability Goals

Goal 1: Reduce Startup Friction

Measures: time-to-start < 30s, interaction cost ≤ 3 actions

- Quick Start still available in ≤ 2 actions (1 click)
- Tasks-first home reduces confusion about where to begin
- Add Task composer with duration chips removes typing barrier
- Cancel option on timer prevents anxiety from accidental starts
- Onboarding tooltips orient first-time users quickly

Goal 2: Support Without Pressure

Measures: sentiment ratio > 2:1, 0 intrusion incidents

- End confirmation prevents accidental session loss
- Celebrating Pudding + encouraging messages add positive motivation
- 'Pudding is napping...' keeps break state guilt-free
- Auto-Move (renamed Smart Dodge) prevents intrusion
- Step progress + checkmarks validate effort visibly

Impact on Design Values & Next Steps

These changes reinforce Pudding's core design values: gentle companionship, invisible progress validation, and low-pressure re-entry.

Next: Usability test the hi-fi prototype to verify (1) startup friction stays under 30s / 3 actions for all users, (2) no participants feel "judged" by the companion, and (3) the celebrating Pudding is perceived as motivating.

What Makes Pudding Different

Pudding fills a gap that existing focus tools don't address.

Forest / Flora

Them: Phone-only, gamified punishment (your tree dies if you leave the app).

Pudding: Pudding is desktop-native and guilt-free — no penalties, just companionship.

Pomodoro Timers

Them: Timer-only tools with no emotional connection or awareness of user behavior.

Pudding: Pudding adds a persistent companion that reacts to how you're doing with mood changes.

Focus Bear

Them: Habit-based routine builder focused on morning/evening routines.

Pudding: Pudding is session-based with real-time emotional feedback during work, not routines.

Centered

Them: Meditation-first approach; focuses on mindfulness and breathing exercises.

Pudding: Pudding is task-first with gentle behavioral nudges — no meditation required.

"Pudding is the only always-present desktop companion that reacts to your behavior with empathy, not guilt."

Try the Prototype

Figma Prototype

https://www.figma.com/proto/fCykx9BqDVUzOD48LjTsq9/Pudding-high-Fidelity-Prototype?node-id=79-11&t=jG6tmAJxLY0QZdGS-1

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